



Document Management System



Sultanate of Oman

Ministry of Health

The Royal Hospital

Department of Emergency and Disaster Preparedness

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Title: THE ROYAL HOSPITAL CRISIS COMMUNICATION PLAN

1.0 PURPOSE:

Royal Hospital is committed in providing accurate, consistent and helpful information in a timely manner about all incidents affecting the hospital.

The Royal Hospital Communication Plan outlines how information will be shared within the hospital as well as with external stakeholders. It serves as a guideline to ensure that information is shared in an organized, efficient and respectful manner.

2.0 KEY PERSONNEL CONTACT NUMBERS:

Ministry of Health Center for Crisis Management (Phone 22357141/ 23357142)

Muscat Governorate Medical Response sector

Director General Royal Hospital Contact 92830111

Assistant Director (Medical) Contact 92880092

Assistant Director (Allied Health) Contact 98987771

Assistant Director (Admin & Finance) Contact 99243619

Director of Nursing Contact 99370400

For all others (e.g. infection control etc refer to on-call lists in the computer system)

3.0 AUTHORITY OF OFFICIAL COMMUNICATION AND MEDIA RELEASE:

During any incident affecting the Royal hospital, the Hospital Director General or designee shall direct all media and communications issues for the hospital. **All hospital-staff must refrain from giving any statement or releasing any audio or visual material to the news media without prior permission from administration.**

4.0 COMMUNICATION DURING MAJOR INCIDENT:

during major incident. These responsibilities include:

- The Office of the Director General (Allied Health) shall ensure that each and every department of the Hospital maintains a call-out list of staff and disaster action plan for the department. The departmental list of staff names, designations and telephone contact numbers shall be updated by January of every year.
- All external notification of major incidents must be directed to adult ER phone 24599453. This number will be shared with all authorities like civil defense as the number to contact to inform about any major incident.
- In the event of any major incident, the Hospital Emergency Response Team (HERT) will be activated by dialing 9444. HERT will lead all response efforts including communications till more senior are around. HERT will verify all external notification by calling back the informer and also calling the MOH center for crisis management. HERT leader will instruct the switchboard to activate the disaster Code 9222 if needed.
- HERT team leader must make sure that members of the Hospital Operation Center are informed as soon as possible (IE Director General and others key personnel). Contact numbers are listed below.
- **Once the disaster Code 9222 is activated, it is the responsibility of the concerned on-duty staff to notify his/her on-call consultant and department/section head or deputy so as to activate the departmental action plan and notify off-duty staff to come to the hospital as specified in the department's call-out list.**
- The Duty Nursing Supervisor shall instruct a Ward Nurse to notify the relevant wards and nursing units – medical, surgical, pediatrics, day-care, intensive care unit, CSSD and operation theatres.

5.0 MODES OF COMMUNICATIONS:

The established mode of communication shall be:

- Public address announcement by the Switchboard Operator
- Digital Enhanced Communication telephones (DECTs)
- GSM Cellular mobile phones
- Landline Telephone
- Mass notification system through Omantel SMS gateway.
- Other social medial modalities like Royal Hospital tweeter account

The specific communication method used will depend upon the scope and duration of the incident and incident management communication requirements.

6.0 COMMUNICATION DURING MAIN POWER FAILURE:

In the event of a main power failure, the backup generator will activate immediately. Telephone service will remain operative and it is expected that the DECT system will be working. Unless there is major shutdown of communication in the country, cellular phones will be used as another means of communication within the hospital. In the event of hospital DECT system failure, staff in the hospital shall rely on the public address system coordinated by the switchboard operator and on staff who may be assigned as 'runners' or 'messengers'.

7.0 COMMUNICATION WITH EXTERNAL AUTHORITIES:

During a major disaster, the Royal Hospital medical response efforts will be in close coordination with the MOH Centre for Crisis Management (Phone 22357141/23357142). The HOC will communicate directly to this Centre through audio-visual conferencing, landline and cellular phones, fax and internet. In the event of major shutdown of communication in the country, Thuraya satellite communication system will be used. The HOC will also communicate directly with other authorities like EMS, Civil Defense or other hospitals as directed by the Incident Commander. If the nature of the emergency is internal, then the HOC will notify the appropriate external authorities as soon as possible and provided pertinent information relating to:

- the nature and scope of the emergency;
- the potential or actual impact on the organization;
- a summary of actions taken (or to be taken) by the organization in response to the emergency;
- What assistance, if any, will be needed from the external authorities?

8.0 COMMUNICATION WITH PATIENTS' FAMILIES:

Relatives or members of the Public will be directed to the Hospital Information Desk at the Hospital Main Entrance and will not be allowed to access the Emergency Department or the site of the incident. The Hospital Information Desk will be manned by 2-3 PROs, 2-3 Social

category. In that eventuality, the PRO shall seek the name of one family next of kin or representative who will be the sole person authorized to receive more detailed information about the victim's condition). The PRO shall facilitate this relative to meet the physician in-charge of the patient to be updated on the nature of injuries, clinical status and care plan. If the victim's identity is known and the relatives have not reported at the Hospital, the PRO shall telephonically notify the family based on the telephone number given by the victim or from the hospital's database. If the patient is to be transferred to another facility, the PRO will communicate that information to patient's family.

9.0 COMMUNICATION WITH THE NEWS MEDIA:

The Incident Commander (Director General), or his assigned deputy, is the only official authorized to speak to the Press or other news media, and to issue any press release during and after a major incident. The news media may seek information from the HOC through the Hospital Information Desk and not directly from any staff or official. All hospital staff must refrain from giving any statement or releasing any audio or visual material to the news media. The HOC Incident Commander will liaise with the MOH Officials, prepare the information content and determine the time and place of any press briefing. Hospital staffs are expressly forbidden from commenting on the likely cause of the incident.

10.0 MANAGEMENT OF PATIENT INFORMATION:

Patient data and privacy shall remain secure at all times. Staffs are not allowed to share any patient information without the approval HOC. Patient information shall be shared with MOH authorities if it is in the best interest of the individual, the community (i.e. for consulting specialized care or asking for more resources) and for clinic-administrative reasons. Patient information shall also be shared with the concerned authorities to identify, locate and notify family members, guardians or anyone else responsible for the individuals' care.

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